

The Urban Monitor

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FEATURES

How to preload Rails scopes

Justin Weiss

This article is also available in Korean , thanks to Soonsang Hong!

Rails' scopes make it easy to find the records you want:

```
irb(main):001:0> Restaurant . first . reviews . positive . count
Restaurant Load (0.4ms) SELECT `restaurants`.* FROM `restaurants` ORDER BY `restaurants`.`id` ASC LIMIT 1 (0.6ms) SELECT COUNT(*) FROM `reviews` WHERE `reviews`.`restaurant_id` = 1 AND (rating > 3.0) => 5
```

But if you're not careful with them, you'll seriously hurt your app's performance.

Why? You can't really preload a scope. So if you tried to show a few restaurants with their positive reviews:

```
irb(main):001:0> restaurants = Restaurant . first ( 5 )
```

```
irb(main):002:0> restaurants . map do | restaurant |
```

```
irb(main):003:1* “ #{ restaurant . name } : #{ restaurant . reviews . positive . length } positive reviews.”
```

```
irb(main):004:1> end
```

```
=> [ “Judd’s Pub: 5 positive reviews.” , “Felix’s Nightclub: 6 positive reviews.” , “Mabel’s Burrito Shack: 7 positive reviews.” , “Kendall’s Burrito Shack: 2 positive reviews.” , “Elisabeth’s Deli: 15 positive reviews.” ]
```

Yep, that's an N+1 query . The biggest cause of slow Rails apps.

You can fix this pretty easily, though, if you think about the relationship in a different way.

Convert scopes to associations

When you use the Rails association methods, like `belongs_to` and `has_many` , your model usually looks like this:

```
irb(main):001:0> Restaurant . first . positive_reviews . count
Restaurant Load (0.2ms) SELECT `restaurants`.* FROM `restaurants` ORDER BY `restaurants`.`id` ASC LIMIT 1 (0.4ms) SELECT COUNT(*) FROM `reviews` WHERE `reviews`.`restaurant_id` = 1 AND (rating > 3.0) => 5
```

Now, you can preload your new association with `includes` :

```
irb(main):001:0> restaurants = Restaurant . includes ( :positive_reviews ). first ( 5 )
Restaurant Load (0.3ms) SELECT `restaurants`.* FROM `restaurants` ORDER BY `restaurants`.`id` ASC LIMIT 5
Review Load (1.2ms) SELECT `reviews`.* FROM `reviews` WHERE (rating > 3.0) AND `reviews`.`restaurant_id` IN (1, 2, 3, 4, 5)
irb(main):002:0> restaurants . map do | restaurant |
irb(main):003:1* “ #{ restaurant . name } : #{ restau-
```

```
rant . positive_reviews . length } positive reviews.”
irb(main):004:1> end => [ “Judd’s Pub: 5 positive reviews.” , “Felix’s Nightclub: 6 positive reviews.” , “Mabel’s Burrito Shack: 7 positive reviews.” , “Kendall’s Burrito Shack: 2 positive reviews.” , “Elisabeth’s Deli: 15 positive reviews.” ]
```

Instead of 6 SQL calls, we only did two.

(Using `class_name` , you can have multiple associations to the same object. This comes in handy pretty often.)

What about duplication?

There still might be a problem here. The `where(“rating > 3.0”)` is now on your `Restaurant` class. If you later changed positive reviews to `rating > 3.5` , you'd have to update it twice!

It gets worse: If you also wanted to grab all the positive reviews a person has ever left, you'd have to duplicate that scope over on the `User` class, too:

It's not very DRY .

There's an easy way around this, though. Inside of `where` , you can use the positive scope you added to the `Review` class:

```
app/models/restaurant.rb class Restaurant { positive },
class_name: “Review” end
```

That way, the idea of what makes a review a positive review is still only in one place.

Scopes are great. In the right place, they can make querying your data easy and fun. But if you want to avoid N+1 queries, you have to be careful with them.

So, if a scope starts to cause you trouble, wrap it in an association and preload it . It's not much more work, and it'll save you a bunch of SQL calls.

Here's how to live: Commit.

Derek Sivers

If you've ever been confused or distracted, with too many options...

If you don't finish what you start...

If you're not with a person you love...

... then you've felt the problem.

The problem is a lack of commitment.

You've been looking for the best person, place, or career.

But seeking the best is the problem.

No choice is inherently the best.

What makes something the best choice?

You.

You make it the best through your commitment to it.

Your dedication and actions make any choice great.

This is a life-changing epiphany.

You can stop seeking the best option.

Pick one and irreversibly commit.

Then it becomes the best choice for you.

Voilà.

When a decision is irreversible, you feel better about it.

When you're stuck with something, you find what's good about it.

When you can't change your situation, you change your attitude towards it.

So remove the option to change your mind.

You think you want more choice and more options.

But when you have unlimited choice, you feel worse.

When you keep all options open, you're conflicted and miserable.

Your thoughts are divided.

Your power is diluted.

Your time is thinly spread.

Indecision keeps you shallow.

Get the deeper pleasure of diving into one choice.

The English word "decide" comes from Latin "to cut off".

Choose one and cut off other options.

To go one direction means you're not going other directions.

When you commit to one outcome, you're united and sharply focused.

When you sacrifice your alternate selves, your remaining self has amazing power.

Ignore other aspects of your life.

Let go of every unnecessary obligation.

Each one seems small, but together, they'll drain your soul.

Focus your attention on the few things you're committed to, and nothing else.

When our ancestors shifted from nomadic hunter-gatherers to settled land developers, human development boomed. We made massive advances when we stopped moving, and committed to one place.

Choose your home.

Stay there for good.

Get to know everything about it.

Even if you've lived there for years, hire a local expert and learn even more about the history, architecture, and areas you haven't explored.

Find a community of like-minded people.

Don't waste your energy fighting norms.

Trust helps your happiness more than income or health.

Invite your neighbors over for a meal.

Make friends.

Make the effort.

Borrow and lend.

Trust and show you can be trusted.

Let them know they can lean on you because you're here to stay.

They'll reciprocate.

You'll be an inseparable part of your community.

The good relationships you build will build you.

Here's how to live: Reinvent yourself regularly.

Derek Sivers

People say everything is connected.

They're wrong.

Everything is disconnected.

There is no line between moments in time.

Something happened.

Something else happened.

People love stories, so they connect two events, calling them cause and effect.

But the connection is fiction.

It's a hard fiction to escape.

"My parents did that, so that's why I did this."

No.

Those two events are not connected.

There is no line between moments in time.

Same with definitions.

"I'm an introvert, so that's why I can't."

No.

Definitions are not reasons.

Definitions are just your old responses to past situations.

What you call your personality is just a past tendency.

New situations need a new response.

Are you more emotional or intellectual?

Early bird or night owl?

Liberal or conservative?

No.

Disagree with the question.

You aren't supposed to be easy to explain.

Putting a label on a person is like putting a label on the water in a river.

It's ignoring the flow of time.

Your identity.

Your meanings.

Your trauma.

They're all based on the core idea that you're in a continuum, living a story.

But there is no line between moments in time.

There is no story.

There is no plot.

Should you try to be consistent with your past self?

Should a newspaper try to be consistent with past news?

You're an ongoing event — a daily improvisation — responding to the situation of the moment.

Your past is not your future.

Whatever happened before has nothing at all to do with what happens next.

There is no consistency.

Nothing is congruent.

Never believe a story.

You've changed so much over time.

Your past self is as different from your current self as you are from other people.

Your past self needs to step down, like a previous president, to let the new you run the show.

Doing what you've always done is bad for your brain.

If you don't change, you'll age faster and get stuck.

The way to live is to regularly reinvent yourself.

Every year or two, change your job and move somewhere new.

Change the way you eat, look, and talk.

Change your preferences, opinions, and usual responses.

Try the opposite of before.

Disconnect from your past.

Cut all common threads.

Keep nothing permanent.

No tattoos.

Remain a clean slate.

Life is _____

Derek Sivers

I was at a workshop, and right before dinner, the teacher wrote this on the whiteboard:

LIFE IS _____

He told us to think about what goes in the blank. He said that after dinner, he'd reveal the meaning of life.

At dinner, I was at a table with seven other people, each arguing about what should go in that blank. One said life is learning. One said life is memory, since if you can't remember your life, it's like it never happened. One said life is love — the most powerful emotion. One said life is giving. One nouveau Buddhist said life is suffering, repeating his recent lessons. One said life is choice, since our choices shape our life. One said life is time, since life is what we call the time between when we're born and when we die.

Each was arguing that their answer was definitely the right one. I'm usually talkative, but I stayed quiet and just listened. Because there were different valid perspectives, it seemed clear that none of these could be the answer.

Then I thought maybe there is no answer — there is no built-in meaning. Maybe life is like a blank canvas for everyone to project their own meaning into.

Oh! Maybe that's why the teacher wrote: "LIFE IS _____". Maybe that's not a question! Maybe "_____" is the answer. Ooooh that's good. I like that a lot.

After dinner, yeah, my hunch was right — that's what the teacher intended. He pointed up and asked, "What's the meaning of this ceiling?" Someone said, "It provides shelter." Someone else said, "Safety. Structure." The teacher said, "Those are your meanings. The ceiling itself has no meaning. It's just a ceiling."

He asked everyone, "What does it mean that you're here today?" Someone said, "It means I'm trying to improve myself." Someone else said, "It means I'm committed." The teacher said, "Those are your meanings. Your presence here today has no inherent meaning."

Then he asked, "So what's the meaning of life?" This time people's answers were emphatic, each arguing for their favorite meaning. The teacher said, "Those are your meanings. Life itself has no meaning." Now people were upset, saying this whole workshop was a scam and they want their money back since they expected an answer.

But I like that "_____" answer a lot. Not just for the meaning of life, but for everything.

You love travelling. What does it mean? You must be running away from something? You're privileged? You're a curious soul, searching for answers? Nah.

Nothing has inherent meaning. Whatever meaning you project into it is your own.

You were just thinking of your long-lost friend this morning, and then they contacted you for the first time in years. What does it mean? Our psychic connections bind us? Our souls are in sync? The universe is sending out energy waves that we can feel? I mean, if you like that idea, why not? If that makes life feel more special, more magical... If that makes you curious about the unseen forces all around us... If that makes you marvel and wonder, then maybe that meaning works for you. Great. Give that event that meaning.

That's coming from you.

Though maybe you need to believe it's true to feel its magic power.

Meanings can help you feel your life is important, with a narrative and purpose. Meanings can help you make peace with events out of your control. Meanings can give you a reason to persist in difficult times.

But they're internal, not external.

They're yours, not others'.

Me? I like the "_____". I like the blank canvas. I love that nothing, in itself, has built-in meaning. I love the creative power of choosing my own. Meanings are useful, not true.

Hegseth Makes Troops Prove “Sincerely Held” Faith in Latest Beard Crackdown

Noah Hurowitz · *The Intercept*

The latest edict from beard-obsessed Secretary of War Pete Hegseth adds strict new regulations to his crusade on facial hair, which rights groups have characterized as an attack on troops’ civil liberties.

In a March 11 memo, Hegseth, who has made grooming and appearances a central focus in his time at the helm of the U. S. military, raised the bar to qualify for a religious exemption to his blanket ban on beards. The guidelines lay out a strict new process by which service members may apply for a religious exemption and subject those who’ve already received one to a reevaluation, arguing they need to ensure their religious beliefs are “sincerely held” and have a genuine conflict with the grooming standards.

Service members who have spoken against Hegseth’s focus on grooming standards say his restrictions on beards are exclusionary to people from religious communities that require adherents to follow specific tenets of faith around beards, hair, and other grooming matters.

Sikhs, for example, who have served in the U. S. military since at least World War I, are required by their faith not to cut the hair on their head, to keep a beard, and to wrap their long hair in a turban. Members of many schools of Muslim tradition likewise have rules around beards and hair length.

A Sikh advocacy group derided the new requirements as “completely unnecessary.”

“Sikhs and other service members of faith already earned their accommodations, under policies and processes established under both the Obama and first Trump Administrations,” the Sikh Coalition said in a statement. “If there are accommodations that the Department of Defense feels are not sincere, they could have chosen to pursue those cases with a process that doesn’t force every single soldier, sailor, airman, guardian, and Marine with an accommodation through more paperwork and bureaucracy.”

The Department of War did not respond to a request for comment.

Military Leaders See Iran War as “God’s Divine Plan” — a Chilling Turn for Trump’s Fascism

Hegseth introduced the new guidelines as the military increasingly embraces overt Christianity and Christian nationalism, including an ideological turn on the Air Force Academy’s oversight board and the presentation of the war on Iran as part of “God’s divine plan.”

The changes come months after Hegseth declared war on “beardos” in a combative speech in September.

“If you want a beard, you can join Special Forces. If not, then shave,” Hegseth said at the time.

In a November letter to Hegseth, four senators — Gary Peters, D-Mich.; Elizabeth Warren, D-Mass.; Tim Kaine, D-Va.; and Kirsten Gillibrand, D-N. Y. — warned that an overly strict grooming standard could force religious service members from the ranks and ultimately harm the military’s primary mission of national security.

“This will happen either by forcing out servicemembers with accommodations earned through carefully following their branch’s established processes or signaling to members of these religious communities that their contributions are not needed in the world’s greatest fighting force,” the senators wrote. “At a time when readiness and retention remain urgent concerns, such a move would be ill-advised.”

Federal courts have repeatedly ruled in favor of service members’ rights to observe tenets of faith while in the military, limiting Hegseth’s ability to put in place an outright ban on any facial hair. He has opted instead to tighten the screws on anyone wishing to get an exemption.

Courts have generally required the military to accommodate sincerely held religious beliefs unless it can demonstrate a compelling operational need.

Under the new rules, anyone applying for an exemption — or facing reevaluation under the new guidelines — must submit a sworn statement affirming their religious beliefs, a statement detailing those beliefs, a statement explaining how the grooming standard would conflict with those beliefs, and supporting evidence backing up their “sincerely held” beliefs. Additionally, anyone applying for an exemption must receive from their unit commander a written assessment of the applicant’s sincerity of belief.

The policy also places commanders in the position of evaluating the sincerity of a service member’s religious beliefs. False statements could expose service members to disciplinary action under the Uniform Code of Military Justice.

The post Hegseth Makes Troops Prove “Sincerely Held” Faith in Latest Beard Crackdown appeared first on *The Intercept*.

The Bitter History of Chocolate

Throughline (NPR)

What’s better than holiday hot chocolate? If just thinking about it makes you feel all warm and fuzzy, well – that’s by design. Chocolate’s big history sweeps across the globe, and today we’re going on that journey: from the pre-Columbus Americas, to an early 20th century reporter’s hunch about what cocoa production really takes, to a 21st century medical student’s story about his childhood on a farm that produces those holiday treats.

Guests:

Carla Martin, lecturer in African and African American Studies at Harvard University and President of the Board of the Institute for Cacao and Chocolate Research

Catherine Higgs, professor of history at the University of British Columbia in Canada

Shadrack Frimpong, founder of Cocoa360

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The Creeping Coup

Throughline (NPR)

Sudan has been at the center of a deadly and brutal war for over a year. It’s the site of the world’s largest hunger crisis, and the world’s largest displacement crisis.

On the surface, it’s a story about two warring generals vying for power – the latest in a long cycle of power struggles that have plagued Sudan for decades. But it’s also a story about the U. S. war on terror, Russia’s war in Ukraine, and China’s global rise.

Today on the show, we turn back the clock more than a century to untangle the complex web that put Sudan on the path to war.

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IN BRIEF

Patrick McKenzie (patio11), patio11 (Patrick McKenzie): I joined Stripe to work on building financial infrastructure for the Internet. Time flies. Here is what I’ve learned in the first four years.

Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): Mitch McConnell has been described as “opaque,” “drab,” and even “dull.” He is one of the least popular - and most polarizing - politicians in the country. So how did he win eight consecutive elections? And what does it tell us about how he operates? This week, we share an episode we loved from Embedded that traces McConnell’s political history.

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Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): A record number of Americans have died from opioid overdoses in recent years. But how did we get here? And is this the first time Americans have faced this crisis? The short answer: no. Three stories of opioids that have plagued Americans for more than 150 years.

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Patrick McKenzie (patio11), patio11 (Patrick McKenzie): Author’s note: This is a copy of the white paper of the Working Group, a group of four pseudonymous professionals in Tokyo. I, Patrick McKenzie, was the primary author. It was distributed quietly during the week of March 25th, 2020. I have written an essay describing how this document came to be and demonstrating its provenance .

Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): Why does Whitney Houston’s 1991 Super Bowl national anthem still resonate 30 years later? Listen to this episode from our friends at It’s Been A Minute with Sam Sanders where they chat with author and Black Girl Songbook host Danyel Smith about that moment of Black history and

Bayard Rustin: The Man Behind the March on Washington

Throughline (NPR)

Bayard Rustin, the man behind the March on Washington, was one of the most consequential architects of the civil rights movement you may never have heard of. Rustin imagined how nonviolent civil resistance could be used to dismantle segregation in the United States. He organized around the idea for years and eventually introduced it to Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. But his identity as a gay man made him a target, obscured his rightful status and made him feel forced to choose, again and again, which aspect of his identity was most important.

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Make believe

Derek Sivers

Kids scream, “Monster in the hallway!”, and hide behind the couch. They stack up cushions for protection, and plan their defense. They know there’s not really a monster in the hallway, but it’s exciting to feel the adrenaline of panic, to make a shelter and feel safe.

One kid yells, “The floor is hot lava!” Leaping between furniture is a fun challenge.

One slips and wails, “Help! I’m falling! Save me! Save me!” Now one kid can feel protected, while the other gets to be the rescuing hero.

Mom calls, “Pancakes are ready!”, and all stories stop when the kids run into the kitchen.

Kids believe anything fun for a while. It’s called “make believe” because they’re making up beliefs.

The game has a purpose. Each belief gives them a new situation, and lets them adopt a new role like protector or inventor.

Grown-ups have their own version of make believe:

“Everything happens for a reason.”

“Those people are evil.”

“I would be creatively prolific if I could quit my job.”

None of these statements are true. But we like the way it feels to believe.

Beliefs have a purpose.

They help us adopt a perspective or identity. They

help us take action, or cooperate with others. The only problem is when we confuse belief with reality, and insist that something is absolutely true because we believe it.

Beliefs don’t exist outside the mind. (Have you ever seen one in nature?) All beliefs are make believe.

Each belief gives them a new situation, and lets them adopt a new role like protector or inventor.

Derek Sivers

Daydreaming is my favorite pastime

Derek Sivers

Somewhere in our past, we were told it's bad to daydream, because it meant doing nothing — staring out the window — instead of doing what we're supposed to be doing. To admit we're daydreaming felt like it needed an apology.

But now I've finally embraced it. Deliberate daydreaming is my favorite pastime.

About half the time that I used to read a book, I now just skip the book, and sit there daydreaming instead. And I almost never watch videos anymore. I just close my eyes and daydream.

I find it most fun to ask myself a big question:

Which were the top three best times in my life so far?

What are my biggest regrets?

What would I write a screenplay about?

If I had the magic lamp, what would be my three wishes?

What does the most ambitious version of myself look like?

What about the least ambitious version of myself?

How can I be a better dad?

At what would I most love to become an expert?

Is there anything I can't do without?

How would my life be different if I was blind? Deaf? Paralyzed?

We've all had plenty of input.

It's fun to let your mind direct its own entertainment.

Afghanistan: The Rise of the Taliban (2021)

Throughline (NPR)

How did a small group of Islamic students go from local vigilantes to one of the most infamous and enigmatic forces in the world? The Taliban is a name that has haunted the American imagination since 2001. The scenes of the group's brutality repeatedly played in the Western media, while true, perhaps obscure our ability to see the complex origins of the Taliban and how they impact the lives of Afghans. It's a shadow that reaches across the vast ancient Afghan homeland, the reputation of the modern state, and throughout global politics. At the end of the US war in Afghanistan we go back to the end of the Soviet Occupation and the start of the Afghan civil war to look at the rise of the Taliban.

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We the People: Gun Rights

Throughline (NPR)

The Second Amendment. In April 1938, an Oklahoma bank robber was arrested for carrying an unregistered sawed-off shotgun across state lines. The robber, Jack Miller, put forward a novel defense: that a law banning him from carrying that gun violated his Second Amendment rights. For most of U. S. history, the Second Amendment was one of the sleepier ones. It rarely showed up in court, and was almost never used to challenge laws. Jack Miller's case changed that. And it set off a chain of events that would fundamentally change how U. S. law deals with guns. Today on Throughline's We the People: How the second amendment came out of the shadows. (Originally ran as The Right to Bear Arms)

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It shows what you need to believe

Derek Sivers

The Lord Of Misrule

Throughline (NPR)

On November 18, 1633, a book went to press in London. Its author, Thomas Morton, had been exiled from the Puritan colonies in Massachusetts for the crimes of drinking, carousing, and – crucially – building social and economic ties with Native people. Back in England, Morton wrote down his vision for what America could become. A very different vision than that of the Puritans.

But the book wouldn't be published that day. It wouldn't be published for years. Because agents for the Puritan colonists stormed the press and destroyed every copy.

Today on the show, the story of what's widely considered America's first banned book, the radical vision it conjured, and the man who outlined that vision: Thomas Morton, the Lord of Misrule.

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The Commentator

Throughline (NPR)

Today the foundations of philosophy are seen as a straight line from Western antiquity, built on thinkers such as Plato and Aristotle. But, between the 8th century and 14th century, the West was greatly overshadowed by the Islamic world and philosophy was in very different hands. This week, how one Medieval Islamic philosopher put his pen to paper and shaped the modern world.

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In Harry Potter, there's a magic mirror that reflects the viewer's desire. What Harry sees in that mirror is very different than what Dumbledore or Ron sees, because their desires are all different.

Imagine if there was something similar that shows you what you most need to believe right now . It shows proof to support whatever perspective would most benefit you. Upon seeing it, you instantly believe it, internalize it, and act upon it.

Someone feeling sadly disconnected might see proof that everyone is connected.

Someone trying to create something might see proof that people will love it.

Someone feeling stuck by the seriousness of life might get un-stuck by the proof that our universe is actually a computer simulation.

Someone with a terminal illness might see proof of a wonderful afterlife with loved ones waiting — to feel joy in their final days.

We don't have to imagine this magic device. We already do this in real life. We find proof to support the perspective we need. Then we believe it.

We don't have to argue what's in the magic mirror, which viewpoints are true or not , because everyone needs different beliefs for their different situations.

When Things Fall Apart (Throwback)

Throughline (NPR)

Climate change, political unrest, random violence - Western society can often feel like what the filmmaker Werner Herzog calls, “a thin layer of ice on top of an ocean of chaos and darkness.” In the United States, polls indicate that many people believe that law and order is the only thing protecting us from the savagery of our neighbors, that the fundamental nature of humanity is competition and struggle. This idea is often called “veneer theory.” But is this idea rooted in historical reality? Is this actually what happens when societies face disasters? Are we always on the cusp of brutality?

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By Accident of Birth

Throughline (NPR)

In August of 1895, a ship called the SS Cop-tic approached the coast of Northern California. On that boat was a passenger from San Francisco, a young man named Wong Kim Ark who was returning home after visiting his wife and child in China. He’d taken trips like this before, and expected to come back to the city he was born in, to his life and friends. But when the ship docked, officials told him he couldn’t get off. The customs agent barred him according to the Chinese Exclusion Act, which denied citizenship to Chinese immigrants. Though Wong Kim Ark had been born in the U. S. and lived his whole life there, the agent said he was not a citizen.

Wong was moved from steamer to steamer for months. But he was able to contact representatives from the Chinese Six Companies, a consortium of Chinese business owners that often hired legal representation for people subject to discrimination. His subsequent legal battles culminated in the 1897 Supreme Court case *United States. v. Wong Kim Ark* : a case that would forever change the path of American immigration law, and play a pivotal role in the ongoing battle over who gets to be a citizen of the United States.

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Palantir Will No Longer Profit Off of New Yorkers' Health Data

Sam Biddle · The Intercept

A controversial multimillion-dollar deal between New York City's public hospital system and military contractor Palantir, first reported by The Intercept, is coming to an end, according to recent testimony before the city council.

Palantir Gets Millions of Dollars From New York City's Public Hospitals

The Intercept reported in February that the New York City Health and Hospitals Corporation, which operates a network of public health care facilities across the city, had paid Palantir almost \$4 million since 2023 for data analysis services. NYCHH says it used Palantir's software to boost its efficiency in billing Medicaid and other public benefits, which included the automated scanning of patient health notes.

The contract prompted protests from activists and local organizers who objected to the hospital system's use of software from a company whose technology has facilitated lethal airstrike targeting, wide-reaching surveillance of American citizens, and deportation raids by Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents.

"They should have no place in our hospitals, our pension funds, or our government."

At a March 16 meeting of the New York City Council, NYC Health + Hospitals CEO Mitchell Katz disclosed that Palantir's contract will not be

renewed come October. Katz defended the health care network's collaboration with Palantir on the grounds that there was an "absolute firewall" between patient data and the company's government customers, such as ICE, that would prevent information sharing. "We haven't had any problems," Katz said, "And we're going to end the contract anyway because we always intended it to be a short-term solution."

According to Katz, data analysis previously conducted with Palantir's help will be brought in-house following the contract's expiration.

Alex Karp Insists Palantir Doesn't Spy on Americans. Here's What He's Not Saying.

"Palantir makes money by enabling mass violence in the U. S. and around the world. They should have no place in our hospitals, our pension funds, or our government," said Kenny Morris, an organizer with the American Friends Service Committee, which shared the contract documents with The Intercept.

"Our campaign against Palantir doesn't stop in NYC," Morris said. "We will continue to isolate this company and limit its destructive influence on our lives. In this city and around the world, communities are organizing to push more and more corporate clients, institutions, and politicians to cut ties with Palantir."

Russia's Vladimir Putin

Throughline (NPR)

Vladimir Putin has been running Russia since 2000 when he was first elected as President. How did a former KGB officer make his way up to the top seat — was it political prowess or was he just the recipient of a lot of good fortune? In this episode, we dive into the life of Vladimir Putin and try to understand how he became Russia's new "tsar."

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“We haven’t had any problems,” Katz said, “And we’re going to end the contract anyway because we always intended it to be a short-term solution.”

Sam Biddle

A daily run and imagination

Derek Sivers

Every day you go for a run.

Sometimes you feel yourself lagging, so you imagine there’s a tiger on your tail, and that adrenaline gives you a turbo boost.

Sometimes you feel like quitting, so you picture a pot of gold at the end, and that helps you finish.

A running expert says you should act like you’re running on hot coals, to keep you on the front of your feet. You try it, and it improves your stamina and energy.

Sometimes, just for a change, you try running barefoot, or with your eyes closed, or with your arms out like an airplane. Every time you hear or think of a new way to run, you try it to see how it works and how you feel. The variety is fun.

All you changed was the image in your mind, and that changed your emotions and actions.

Ideas and beliefs are tools.

Choose them for the desired effect.

The Queen of Tupperware

Throughline (NPR)

Who ushered housewives into the workforce and plastic storage containers into America’s kitchens? Today on the show, the rise and fall of Brownie Wise, the woman behind Tupperware’s plastic empire — and a revolution in women’s work.

Guests: Alison Clarke , author of *Tupperware, the Promise of Plastic in 1950s America* Bob Kealing , author of *Life of the Party: The Remarkable Story of How Brownie Wise Built, and Lost, a Tupperware Party Empire*

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Judge the contents, not the box

Derek Sivers

My cousin took a course on a complete system for physical fitness and health, and followed every bit of its advice. She had great results at first. But then she saw the coach's social media posts, and hated his political beliefs, so now she doesn't follow that course at all.

A best-selling book on psychology is filled with wisdom that would improve your life, if applied. But a few sentences were found to be plagiarized, or some of its studies don't replicate. So people trash the whole book and refuse to read it.

That's the problem with judging a box instead of its contents. It's seeking "true" instead of useful. When any aspect of a package is flawed, it no longer feels "true", so all of it is discarded. You lose all of the benefits.

Think of a famous person you despise, perhaps a politician or celebrity that represents everything wrong with the world. Now imagine hearing that person say something you really like. Hard to imagine, right? You've probably pre-decided that anything that comes out of that person's mouth is going to be bad. No matter what they say, you're against it, in advance. Judging someone as good or bad, instead of each individual idea as useful or not.

Listen to ideas, not their messenger. Focus on the contents, not the box. Avoid ideology.

You've probably heard the phrase, "Perfect is the enemy of good." Likewise:

True is the enemy of useful.

Doors and windows and what's real

Derek Sivers

Like everyone, I live in a little house with many doors and windows.

One door goes out to my neighborhood. The local kids come to play with my dog. The elderly neighbors take so long to tell me their stories. I slow down my inner clock to listen.

One window looks out at the nature around me. I'm getting to know this one tree really well. I toss a little dog food out there each day, and watch the local birds and rodents come by to eat it.

One door is just for my son. This door goes somewhere new every time he opens it. I pause what I'm doing and follow him on an adventure. My inner clock stops working through that door.

One door goes to my connections — the people around the world with mutual interests. A dozen people a day knock on this door and say hello. Sometimes more.

One hidden door is for my dearest friends. That one comes all the way inside, anytime.

One skylight looks far into the future. I daydream there a lot.

One little locket looks at the past. I daydream there, too.

But one door is really no fun to open. Whenever I do, I'm horrified at all the shouting. It's an infinite dark room filled with psychologically tortured people, trying to get attention. Strangers screaming at strangers, starting fights.

Businesses put windows there, showing bad things said and done today, because they make money when people get mad.

They say I'm supposed to open that door, because that's the real world.

But it seems a lot less real than what's in the other doors and windows in my life.

Useful?

Derek Sivers

Let's define "useful" as whatever ultimately helps you do what you need to do, be who you want to be, or feel at peace .

The word "ultimately" is there as a reminder of long-term consequences.

Is it more useful to make others see your point of view, or make yourself see theirs?

Is it more useful to think you're right, or to consider other perspectives?

Is it more useful to make your life easier, or make yourself stronger?

Is it ultimately more useful to benefit only yourself, or benefit others?

It depends on who you want to be and what helps you feel at peace.

Octavia Butler: Visionary Fiction (2021)

Throughline (NPR)

Octavia Butler's alternate realities and 'speculative fiction' reveal striking, and often devastating parallels to the world we live in today. She was a deep observer of the human condition, perplexed and inspired by our propensity towards self-destruction. Butler was also fascinated by the cyclical nature of history, and often looked to the past when writing about the future. Along with her warning is her message of hope - a hope conjured by centuries of survival and persistence. For every society that perishes in her books comes a story of rebuilding, of repair.

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CodeSOD: Awaiting A Reaction

Remy Porter · The Daily WTF

Today's Anonymous submitter sends us some React code. We'll look at the code and then talk about the WTF:

```
// inside a function for
updating checkboxes on
a page if (e.target .
checked) { const removeIndex
= await checkedlist.
findIndex ( ( sel ) =>
sel. Id == selected. Id , )
const removeRowIndex =
await RowValue . findIndex
( ( sel ) => sel == Index , )
```

// checkedlist and RowValue are both useState instances.... they should never be modified directly
await checkedlist. splice (removeIndex, 1)
await RowValue . splice (removeRowIndex, 1)

```
// so instead of doing
above logic in the set state,
they dont setCheckedlist
(checkedlist) setRow ( RowValue ) } else { if
(checkedlist. findIndex
( ( sel ) => sel. Id ==
selected. Id ) == - 1 )
{ await checkedlist. push
(selected) } // same, instead
of just doing a
set state call, we do
awaits and self updates
await RowValue . push
( Index ) setCheckedlist
(checkedlist) setRow ( RowValue ) }
```

Comments were added by our submitter.

This code works. It's the wrong approach for doing things in React: modifying objects controlled by react, instead of using the provided methods, it's doing asynchronous push calls. Without the broader context, it's hard to point out all the other ways to do this,

but honestly, that's not the interesting part.

I'll let our submitter explain:

This code is black magic, because if I update it, it breaks everything. Somehow, this is working in perfect tandem with the rest of the horrible page, but if I clean it up, it breaks the checkboxes; they're no longer able to be clicked. Its forcing React somehow to update asynchronously so it can use these updated values correctly, but thats the neat part, they aren't even being used anywhere else, but somehow the re-rendering page only accepts awaits. I've tried refactoring it 5 different ways to no avail

That's what makes truly bad code. Code so bad that you can't even fix it without breaking a thousand other things. Code that you have to carefully, slowly, pick through and gently refactor, discovering all sorts of random side-effects that are hidden. The code so bad that you actually have to live with it, at least for awhile.

[Advertisement] BuildMaster allows you to create a self-service release management platform that allows different teams to manage their applications. Explore how!

The Modern White Power Movement (2020)

Throughline (NPR)

The recent shooting in Buffalo, New York, which authorities are investigating as a hate crime, has yet again highlighted the threat posed by domestic terrorism in the U. S. At the center are violent extremists – the most lethal and persistent of whom are white supremacists and anti-government militias. They're part of a deeply interconnected movement which, since the 1980s, has pursued a mission to topple the U. S government with guerrilla warfare. Today, this movement is made up of highly-organized groups with paramilitary capabilities, but it hasn't always been this way. This week, we trace the rise of the modern white power movement.

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The lasting legacy of the slave patrols

Throughline (NPR)

To this day, America continues to grapple with the legacy of slavery. On this week's episode, we explore the creation of slave patrols, which were created to control the movement of enslaved Black people in the 1700s, and how those patrols shaped American society and modern policing. To access bonus episodes and listen to Throughline sponsor-free, subscribe to Throughline+ via Apple Podcasts or at plus.npr.org/throughline.

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Considerate book pricing

Derek Sivers

I love having my own store so I can make things the way I think they should be.

For example, I disagree with the usual pricing of books. If I buy a book in one format, it doesn't seem fair to pay full price to get it in another format. That would be paying twice for the same content.

Let's separate these two things:

Contents : the words in a book

Delivery : the ways to get the words into your brain: paper, audio, PDF, HTML, etc.

What we really want is to buy the contents, not delivery .

With so many different devices now, it seems fair that if you buy the contents of a book, it should include all formats of delivery. EPUB, MP3, Kindle, M4B, PDF, HTML, or whatever new formats may come in the future.

Today you want to read silently by the fire. Tomorrow you want to listen while you drive. In ten years, you want to read it again on your new device.

This should all be included when you buy a book.

I love this idea. It's almost perfect. It has just one problem:

Paper costs money.

So I can't just include it for free.

But following this philosophy, it's not right to charge

full price for each paper book, because that would mean paying repeatedly for the contents!

So here's the solution I came up with:

Contents of my book: \$15

Delivery of all digital formats: FREE

Paper? Just cover its cost: \$4 each (+ postage)

I like this.

It means you never pay for the contents twice.

It works out well for many different scenarios:

All digital formats: \$15

First paper book: \$19

Paper books after you've bought the contents: \$4 each

Loved the ebook, and now want to buy 20 paper copies for your friends? Just \$4 each, so \$80 total for 20 hardcover books .

It's worked out well. People are buying many hardcover copies as gifts. A few people have bought over 500 copies each to give to clients or members of their organization.

The only downside of creative pricing is it requires a little explanation. Like anything unusual.

Log in to sivers.com to get my books. ☺

See my previous article on pricing philosophy for more thoughts on creative pricing .

Read " Make a dream come true " for more thoughts on making things the way they should be

The Dance of the Dead (2021)

Throughline (NPR)

Long before it was a sugary moviefest, the Halloween we know was called Samhain. The Celts of ancient Ireland believed Samhain was a night when the barrier between worlds was thin, the dead could cross over, and if you didn't disguise yourself, evil fairies might spirit you away. Over time the holiday shape-shifted too, thanks to the Catholic Church, pagan groups, and even the brewing company Coors. From the Great Famine of Ireland to Elvira and the Simpsons, we present the many faces of Halloween.

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Anything You Want — third edition for 2022

Derek Sivers

In 2011, I got a phone call from a number I didn't recognize.

"Hello?"

"Derek. It's Seth Godin."

"Wow! Hi Seth!"

"I'm starting a new publishing company, so I want you to write a book. Short, like a manifesto. Will you do it?"

"Uh, sure!"

"Great. I look forward to it."

"Thanks!"

Over the next eleven days, I wrote the lessons I'd learned from starting, growing, and selling my company. He liked it, named it "Anything You Want", and a few weeks later it was for sale. My first book. Simple as that.

To me, it was no big deal - just telling my tale. But a lot of small business owners said my book helped them remember their purpose, and get re-excited about their business.

Penguin bought Seth's publishing company and re-released my book on Penguin Portfolio. But I wanted to self-publish.

I want to own the rights to my books so I can do what I want with them: give them away, let people translate them, or sell them how I like. I'm thinking long-term. I've got many books to come, and I want them to be a matching set.

So I bought back the rights from Penguin.

I improved many chapters in "Anything You Want", and added eight new chapters that were missing — points that people kept asking about over my last ten years of talking about this book — better explanations — better stories.

Then I gave it a new cover to match all of my other books. (White, to represent its innocent naïveté.) I recorded the new audiobook, better than before.

And now, it's finally available, in its third and final edition, directly from me.

"ANYTHING YOU WANT: 40 lessons for a new kind of entrepreneur"

Get it at sivers.com.

There are only 5000 limited-edition linen hardcovers printed, so get that version while they last. Even if you already read it, consider getting this as the permanent edition.

The first copy is \$19, which is \$15 for the content, and \$4 for the paper itself.

All future copies cost only the price of the paper: \$4.

Paper books include all digital formats for free. As before, I'm giving all profits to charity.

) I recorded the new audiobook , better than before.

Derek Sivers

The Hidden War

Throughline (NPR)

How does a country go from its leader winning the Nobel Peace Prize to all-out war in just one year? That's the question surrounding Ethiopia, which has become embroiled in one of the deadliest wars of the 21st century. The U. S. has called it an ethnic cleansing campaign against Tigrayans, a minority group in the country; some human rights organizations have called it a genocide. But many people outside Ethiopia and its diaspora had no idea it was happening. In U. S. media, it's hardly discussed, even as violence has intensified throughout the country. In this episode, we tell the story of Ethiopia — the oldest independent country in Africa — and the political, cultural and religious factors that led to this war.

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Before Roe: The Physicians' Crusade

Throughline (NPR)

Abortion wasn't always controversial. In fact, in colonial America it would have been considered a fairly common practice: a private decision made by women, and aided mostly by midwives. But in the mid-1800s, a small group of physicians set out to change that. Obstetrics was a new field, and they wanted it to be their domain—meaning, the domain of men and medicine. Led by a zealous young doctor named Horatio Storer, they launched a campaign to make abortion illegal in every state, spreading a potent cloud of moral righteousness and racial panic that one historian later called “the physicians' crusade.” And so began the century of criminalization.

In the first episode of a two-part series, we're telling the story of that century: how doctors put themselves at the center of legal battles over abortion, first to criminalize — and then to legalize.

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